

A litmus test

Messi's **Inter Miami** will open the 2026 World Cup against Egyptian champion Al Ahly Sporting Club on June 14.

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Lionel Messi's move to the United States after winning the 2022 World Cup made the country an immediate hotspot for football events, and FIFA did not disappoint.

Although the 2026 World Cup was already scheduled, its precursor was announced just months after Qatar 2022: an expanded format of the Club World Cup set for June 2025, featuring 32 sides from around the world.

The draw for the tournament took place in December in Miami, accompanied by a message from the USA's re-elected president, Donald Trump. Messi's Inter Miami will open the tournament against Egyptian champion Al Ahly Sporting Club on June 14.

NASA-inspired trophy

The Club World Cup will merge two international tournaments — its successor (retaining the same name) and the FIFA Intercontinental Cup — and will feature a new trophy inspired by NASA's Voyager space missions.

The golden shield comprises a series of discs that can transform into a 'multifaceted and orbital structure'. It includes engravings in 13 languages and Braille, and it sits on a black plinth adorned with FIFA's emblem in gold typeface.

A packed schedule

The tournament, however, has raised several questions about the sheer number of matches in a calendar year, particularly from FIFPRO and the World Leagues Forum.

Ballon d'Or winner Rodri and Asian Player of the Year Son Heung-Min are among the prominent players who have voiced concerns over the congested schedule.

The year 2025 is poised to be a real test for football scheduling, with an expanded Club World Cup, a restructured UEFA Champions League, and, finally, a 48-team World Cup the following year.



Talisman: Lionel Messi has had an immediate impact at Inter Miami, scoring 21 goals in 25 league matches in his two seasons at the club so far. GETTY IMAGES

FIFA Club World Cup 2025 draw

UNITED STATES, JUNE 15 - JULY 13
Top two from each group progress to knockout stage

GROUP A		GROUP B	
Palmeiras	BRA	Paris St-Germain	FRA
Porto	POR	Atlético Madrid	ESP
Al Ahly	EGY	Botafogo	BRA
Inter Miami	USA	Seattle Sounders	USA
GROUP C		GROUP D	
Bayern Munich	GER	Flamengo	BRA
Auckland City	NZL	ES Tunis	TUN
Boca Juniors	ARG	Chelsea	ENG
Benfica	POR	Club León	MEX
GROUP E		GROUP F	
River Plate	ARG	Fluminense	BRA
Urawa Reds	JPN	Dortmund	GER
Monterrey	MEX	Ulsan HD	KOR
Internazionale	ITA	Mamelodi	RSA
GROUP G		GROUP H	
Manchester City	ENG	Real Madrid	ESP
Wydad AC	MAR	Al Hilal	KSA
Al-Ain	UAE	Pachuca	MEX
Juventus	ITA	Salzburg	AUT

Host venues: Atlanta, Cincinnati, Charlotte, Los Angeles, Miami, Nashville, New York New Jersey, Orlando (two stadia), Philadelphia, Seattle, Washington

Sunday, July 13 CLUB WORLD CUP FINAL MetLife Stadium, NJ

Source: FIFA

Picture: Getty Images

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